

A NEW LIFE FOR THE OLD
Founder Prasad Bhide at an Aaji Care centre in Mumbai

MILIND SHELTE

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Since its inception, Aaji Care has served almost 20,000 elders and trained 3,000 caregivers**
- **It maintains five assisted-living centres. Their goal for the next five years is to have 1,000 beds across 10 cities**
- **They also aim to provide 3,000 families with domestic caregivers**

Around 20 senior citizens are seated for a yoga class, being assisted by a host of young caregivers. Though some days of the week are occupied by such fitness activities, including physiotherapy, there is leisure too—weekly movie nights, trips to gardens and restaurants, and bhajan renditions. Welcome to Aaji Care, an assisted living centre for elders diagnosed with dementia or in need of post-operative and palliative care. With a staff that includes nurses, geriatric counsellors and therapists, the centre is a viable alternative for those unable to devote time to ailing parents.

"I always knew I wanted to help people and make a difference," says Prasad Bhide, Founder and CEO of Aaji Care. In 2011, when his own mother was bedridden for three months and needed specialised care at home, Bhide discovered a giant void in the senior healthcare sector in India. "What struck me was that there was no training for those working at home with the elderly. In most cases, the domestic help would be asked to assist," he says. Bhide did a two-month diploma in home health education from Bayada, one of the largest providers in the United States, moved to India to understand the market and subsequently quit his well-paying job at TCS to start Aaji Care. He began with a training centre for caregivers which didn't just familiarise them with the challenges faced by the elderly but worked to change the attitudes of families towards domestic caregivers, so that they could have more professional dignity. "Everyone wants to be in the comfort of their home, that's the first choice. There's still a lot of stigma attached to keeping parents in assisted-living centres. Families wonder, *'Log kya kahenge* (What will people say)?' We offer them counselling to help them understand the benefits," he says. "To care for the elderly, one needs people who are compassionate and patient. Before being hired, our attendants undergo a thorough psychological assessment."

As the demand to set up more centres across India increases, Bhide has so far resisted the franchise model. "Quality work is needed. We need to make it 100 per cent foolproof," he says. For now, his focus is to start a retail shop with products for senior citizens. Talks are on with builders to develop retirement homes for 55-80-year-olds in cities. "I don't want to disrupt their social circle," he says.

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"My father, 90, has age-related cognitive issues. Aaji Care's attendant gradually connected with him. Old people can be stubborn, but he went from never leaving the house to going for walks and doing crosswords. You want your parents to be happy. My father is"

SANJAY MADHUKAR KIMBAHUNE
Senior IT professional

From being the lone soldier in this field a decade back, Bhide has seen the sector grow, but admits that there is still a long way to go. India still has no council to register caregivers for elders and there are no standards in place for senior care centres. Bhide is working with the National Accreditation Board for Hospitals to release guidelines and get Aaji Care its certification. "Caregivers will transform the economy like engineers and nurses have," he says. "In the next 10 years, we will start exporting caregivers to other countries with an ageing population." ■